



BLUE ECONOMY

20th July, 2026

WHAT
IF?

... our aquatic resources could create jobs, feed communities, power homes, inspire new inventions and protect our coastlines, while remaining healthy and full of life?

That is the promise of the blue economy.

What does “Blue Economy” really mean?

The blue economy is a concept that promotes the sustainable use of oceans, coasts, rivers, lakes and other aquatic resources to create jobs, improve livelihoods and support economic development, while maintaining the health of these ecosystems for future generations. An activity is not “blue” simply because it takes place on or near water. It must use aquatic resources responsibly, protect biodiversity, minimize pollution and generate fair benefits for coastal communities in order to be “truly blue”.

West Africa’s Prosperity Lies Within Healthy Waters

 West Africa’s blue economy has enormous potential to drive inclusive growth through fisheries, aquaculture, coastal tourism, shipping, renewable energy and ecosystem restoration. Coastal tourism alone accounts for an estimated 4.8% of regional GDP, while fisheries sustain food supplies, trade and millions of livelihoods across the region.

 More than 40% of fish is traded across a national border before consumption, and women constitute over 80% of small-scale fish processors and traders, demonstrating the sector’s importance for regional commerce and women’s economic empowerment.

 With sustainable investment, effective governance and healthy aquatic ecosystems, the blue economy can create jobs for coastal communities, women and young people, strengthen food security and build climate-resilient coastal communities.

Let’s Go Blue!

A thriving blue economy begins with healthy aquatic ecosystems and empowered people. As women in aquatic science and management, WASMaN members can help ensure that West Africa’s waters generate prosperity without sacrificing biodiversity, community rights or the opportunities of future generations.

Use your knowledge. Raise your voice. Build partnerships. Help shape a blue economy that works for people, nature and the future.